



## Reader's Companion — *The Uncatalogued Book*

*A reader's aid, not a substitute. A map and a memory-jog for a story that crosses half the world over sixty years. Using it means reading harder, not reading less.*

Companion to RMB\_HISTORY\_REFERENCE.md, which covers the **real history** behind the famous figures (Bruno, Galileo, Dara Shikoh, the manuscript hunt). This file instead covers the **flow of the book itself** — where the narrator goes, when, and how the places sit in relation to one another.

---

## 1. The Narrator's Travels — and the geography they cover



Figure 1: Map of the narrator's travels — Rome east to Agra/Delhi

*The eastward routes are drawn to the book; the faint dotted homeward leg (1659–61) is schematic — the road home runs up the Persian Gulf and overland via Aleppo.*

### The one thing to hold in your head

The whole book is essentially **one line running west to east**, and the narrator keeps getting **pulled further east**. Picture a single arrow:

**Rome** → **Venice** (still Italy) → **Constantinople** (= modern Istanbul, the hinge between Europe and Asia) → *overland east* → **Isfahan** (central Iran) → *down to* the **Persian Gulf** → *by sea around Arabia to* **Surat** (India's west coast) → up to **Agra / Delhi** (north India).

Everything else is a short spur off that spine. From his base at **Isfahan**, **Qom** is a bit north and **Shiraz** → **the Gulf coast** is straight south. He does turn west twice — the 1629 recall to Rome (which the book flags as remarkable: “*the first westward leg of my career*”) and the final 1659–61 homecoming carrying the *Sirr* — but only the first is dramatized on the page; the long road home with the manuscript happens off-stage, between Chapters 24 and 25. The eastward pull is the one the telling *follows*.

That's the key. He always travels **east, upstream, toward the source**, because that is where collapsing libraries and cheap manuscripts are. **The geography and the meaning are the same arrow**: one road, going east, deeper with each movement of the book.

### A plainer mental model with modern names

- **Italy** — Rome, then Venice (the start; home).
- **Constantinople / Istanbul** — the doorway from Europe into the East; everything Rome-bound ships from here.
- **Persia / Iran** — Isfahan is the great central city; New Julfa is the Armenian quarter just across the river there. Qom (north) and Shiraz → the Persian Gulf port of Bandar (south) are day-trips by the scale of this book.
- **The Levant** — Aleppo (in modern Syria) is the inland junction that links Persia back to the Mediterranean coast; the mail and the homeward road run through it.
- **India** — reached **by sea** from the Gulf: Surat is the western port of entry; Agra and Delhi are the inland Mughal capitals to the north.
- **China** — never visited; it reaches the book only as letters and one traveler.

### The travels by date

*All legs are as written (Chapters 1–25).*

| Years   | From → To                      | How      | Where it is   | What happens there                                          |
|---------|--------------------------------|----------|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1600    | <b>Rome</b> (home)             | —        | Italy         | Bruno's cell and the burning. Niccolò is 17.                |
| 1606–08 | Rome → <b>Venice</b>           | by water | N. Italy      | Flight from a poisoned city; apprenticed to the book trade. |
| 1609–14 | <b>Venice / Padua</b>          | local    | N. Italy      | Galileo's telescope; recruited as a manuscript agent.       |
| 1614–17 | Venice → <b>Constantinople</b> | by sea   | the Bosphorus | Greek monasteries, the source; the 1616 decree.             |

| Years       | From → To                                               | How                                                     | Where it is                                              | What happens there                                                                    |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1617        | Constantinople<br>→ <b>Isfahan</b>                      | overland, ~5<br>months                                  | via Armenian<br>country & Tabriz,<br>into central Persia | Half the world; New Julfa;<br>Marjan.                                                 |
| ~1619       | Isfahan → <b>Qom</b><br>& back                          | overland, ~10<br>days each<br>way                       | just north of Isfa-<br>han                               | Buying the philosopher<br>Mulla Sadra's work.                                         |
| ~1620       | <b>Isfahan</b>                                          | (no travel)                                             | central Persia                                           | The forgery Marjan<br>catches.                                                        |
| 1622–<br>23 | Isfahan → Shiraz<br>→ <b>Bandar</b> (Per-<br>sian Gulf) | overland, ~5<br>weeks down<br>the mountain<br>“ladders” | straight south to<br>the coast                           | The coffin caravan; Hor-<br>muz falls; the wreck-buy.                                 |
| 1629        | Isfahan →<br><b>Rome</b>                                | overland west<br>via <b>Aleppo</b>                      | back across to Italy                                     | <b>The recall — his first<br/>journey westward.</b>                                   |
| 1630–<br>33 | <b>Rome / Flo-<br/>rence</b>                            | local                                                   | Italy                                                    | The cold new patron;<br>Galileo's trial.                                              |
| 1641        | Rome → <b>Isfa-<br/>han</b> , then on-<br>ward east     | overland                                                | Persia → toward<br>India                                 | “The choice”: he leaves<br>Marjan for the last time.                                  |
| 1642–<br>51 | <b>Surat</b> , then <b>Agra</b><br>& <b>Delhi</b>       | by sea to In-<br>dia, then in-<br>land                  | W. coast → N. In-<br>dia                                 | Dara Shikoh's circle; the<br>gathering of forbidden<br>books.                         |
| 1657–<br>59 | <b>Delhi / Agra</b>                                     | local                                                   | N. India                                                 | The succession war;<br>Samugarh (1658); the be-<br>heading (1659); the pur-<br>chase. |
| 1659–<br>61 | Delhi → <b>Rome</b>                                     | sea + over-<br>land, ~2 years                           | via Surat, the Gulf,<br>Aleppo                           | The <i>Sirr-i-Akbar</i> carried<br>home.                                              |
| ~1665       | <b>Rome</b>                                             | —                                                       | Italy                                                    | The frame: the old man<br>telling the whole of it to<br>Tommaso.                      |

(For exact route notes, travel times, and the deliberate letter/news lag the book uses, see the working tracker *GEOGRAPHY\_STATE.md*.)

## 2. The Book in Plain English (compressed)

*A short, plain-language walk-through of the story — one paragraph per chapter — for a reader who wants to keep the thread or revisit the shape of the whole. Written from the chapters as they actually exist, not the plan.*

**Status: complete — filled through Chapter 25** (Movements 1–7), the whole book.

### **The heart of it**

Two threads run under the whole sixty years. The first is a **question**, put to a boy of seventeen by Giordano Bruno in his cell — *is there one truth under all the warring revelations, and can any throne survive the man who says so?* — and lived out two generations later by the prince Dara Shikoh, who gathers forbidden scriptures instead of burning them. The prince loves that question in the open and dies for it; Niccolò, the dealer, loves it in secret and lives by never once admitting he does, pricing it on his ledger instead of answering it. They are its two lovers — the open one and the hidden one.

The second thread is the deeper one, and it is a **person**. Marjan — the Armenian book-keeper of New Julfa, the one soul who ever read Niccolò all the way to the bottom — is the love he left, and left no road back to, and by his own first law (*a thing without an entry does not exist*) she is the true uncatalogued book the title means. The prince's fall is the public grief; the private grief, the one the whole telling is bent toward, is that Niccolò never set her right and now never can. The book does not end on the prince's name. It ends on hers.

### **Movement 1 — Rome, 1600 (the wound) · Ch 1–3**

**Ch 1 (Rome, ~1665 — the frame).** In a cardinal's library, the narrator — Niccolò Ferrucci, past eighty, half-blind — is cataloguing a collection he spent his life filling. A young printer's son, Tommaso, hired to copy, finds a Persian manuscript that isn't in the catalogue and asks what it is. Niccolò refuses to say, then begins the long telling. We learn his trade (a hunter of rare books), his lifelong rule — *a book without a catalogue entry does not exist* — and hear of his old rival, the Frenchman Vautier.

**Ch 2 (Rome, 1600 — the cell).** At seventeen, Niccolò is a temporary clerk for an Inquisition notary and carries papers into the cell of Giordano Bruno, eight years imprisoned and about to be condemned. Bored and doomed, Bruno talks to the curious boy and tosses him a careless question — *when they burn me, will there be one star fewer? What do they think they're burning? Who told them they could reach so high?* The boy doesn't understand it; he thinks he's been asked to count the stars.

**Ch 3 (Rome, 1600 — the fire).** The sentence is read to Bruno (the one line history records), and he is burned in the Campo de' Fiori. The narrator refuses to describe the fire itself. The horror he fixes on instead is the crowd's calm — no fear anywhere, “only the calm of work going well.” This is the wound that runs under the rest of his life.



## **Movement 2 — Venice / Padua, 1606–1614 (the trade) · Ch 4–5**

**Ch 4 (Venice, 1606–08).** Rome has become unbearable, so Niccolò goes to Venice — the one Italian city then openly defying the Pope, and notably *unafraid*. He apprentices to the bookdealer Coronaro, who teaches the trade’s first law: *dealers sit; hunters go upstream — the profit, and the forgeries, live at the source*. Coronaro means it as advice to stay safe; Niccolò hears the opposite and resolves to become a hunter.

**Ch 5 (Venice / Padua, 1609–14).** Galileo demonstrates his telescope and sells it to Venice — not as a window on the heavens but as a military spyglass, priced by the ounce. The same sky that burned Bruno now pensions Galileo; the difference is only “the wrapping and the buyer.” Niccolò is recruited as a field agent for Cardinal Ascanio Vitelleschi and takes his first shopping list — pocketing the money of the same Church that lit the fire, and knowing it.

## **Movement 3 — Constantinople, 1614–1617 (the first commission) · Ch 6**

**Ch 6 (Constantinople, 1614–17).** Buying Greek manuscripts at the source. A genuine old codex goes home clean — the method working. But his other cargo, banned astronomy bought legally, is turned into contraband behind his back when Rome’s 1616 decree finally reaches the East months late: its value doubles the day it’s condemned, and carrying it becomes a hanging matter. A broker turns on him; he escapes by night and takes a knife to the forearm. Truth-as-contraband now has a price paid in skin.

## **Movement 4 — Isfahan & the Gulf, 1617–1629 (the richest posting) · Ch 7–11**

**Ch 7 (Isfahan, 1617).** Five months overland brings him to Isfahan and its Armenian quarter, New Julfa. At the merchant house of Khoja Sarkis he meets Marjan, who keeps the books — and who quietly proves he’s been losing money on the exchange all season. He doesn’t argue; he makes the house his base and her his partner. Her people were carried off whole from their old city by a king’s decree, so she already understands what Niccolò is only beginning to learn about thrones.

**Ch 8 (the Qom road, ~1619).** Sent north to buy the work of Mulla Sadra, a philosopher denounced by the local clergy. Sadra, a man whose fear has been ground into wisdom, willingly blesses the copy bound for Rome *because* Niccolò believes none of it — the perfectly safe courier, “the empty cart.” A Persian heresy grows *safer* the farther west it travels — the exact mirror of the lethal westbound cargo in Constantinople.

**Ch 9 (Isfahan, ~1620).** A beautifully forged illustrated manuscript fools Niccolò’s expert eye twice; Marjan catches it by *hand*, feeling the forger’s hesitations as she copies it. The romance becomes real. Against his old instinct, Niccolò un-deceives the buyer though staying silent would be safe and profitable — because in this trade *the name is the goods*, and a house’s good name compounds over generations. The rival Vautier appears in person and, by dodging the fake, “wins by losing.”

**Ch 10 (the Persian Gulf, 1622–23).** He travels down the mountain “ladders” to the coast and falls in with the famous traveler della Valle, who is carrying his embalmed wife home to Rome in a camphor-packed case. The fortress-island of Hormuz falls, and Niccolò buys a sacked church’s

whole library by the pound off an unpaid soldier — feeling nothing but “the clean satisfaction of a sum that has come out well.” The cost of that coldness is something he won’t reckon for decades.

**Ch 11 (Isfahan, 1629).** A packet arrives five months stale: his patron Ascanio is dead, and the cold nephew who inherits, Ottavio, summons him to Rome to “render an accounting.” Niccolò doesn’t weigh it — he calculates, and goes, to protect his standing before a rival can take his place. It is the first parting from Marjan that truly costs him; she doesn’t ask him to stay, he promises to return (and will), and he rides *west* for the first time in his life.

#### **Movement 5 — Rome / Florence, 1630–1633 (the logic completes) · Ch 12–13**

**Ch 12 (Rome, 1630 — the frame returns).** Back in a colder Rome after twelve years east, Niccolò finds his father’s old shop turned into a chandler’s and the warm patronage gone with it. The dead Ascanio’s nephew, Cardinal Ottavio, is a ledger of a man — soft-voiced, fleshy, all bookkeeping — and he prices Niccolò’s lifelong usefulness openly: not a threat, just a filing. Ottavio demands that the dangerous notebook of the Persian philosopher (bought on the Qom road, Ch 8) be surrendered for “correction” — meaning destruction. Niccolò neither burns it nor hands it over. He buries it in plain sight: enters it in the catalogue under a false, nameless description — “*a scholar’s exercise, of no account*” — and shelves it among harmless grammars. This is the first uncatalogued book, and the trick the whole novel turns on: *a book with the wrong entry is worse than one that’s gone — it’s buried alive in plain sight*. In the frame, the old man teaches Tommaso exactly that lesson. Niccolò tells himself he did it out of thrift, not conscience.

**Ch 13 (Rome, 1633 — Galileo’s trial).** Galileo’s banned *Dialogo* is the hottest contraband in Europe — condemned at Rome, so its price doubles and trebles overnight, and Niccolò has copies to sell. Galileo himself, near seventy and broken, is brought to Rome and made to kneel and recant before the cardinals: no fire this time, just house arrest and a signed paper. Niccolò works it all from the edges, and catches himself doing the unforgivable — *pricing* the ruin even as it sickens him. He crosses the old man afterward in a loggia (white-bearded now, the lens-grinder’s thumb still flat and shining) and hears him console himself: *let them have the words; the words are not the thing*. It is Niccolò’s own buried-notebook trick in a great man’s mouth — give the record the lie, keep the truth in yourself — and he recognizes it in silence. He sees the cleaner method the age has learned: you no longer have to burn a man, only make him sign that his mind was never his. And he has no standing to wish Galileo braver, having taken Rome’s purse over the fire his whole life. He sells the copies coldly and feels nothing — and that numbness, not grief, is what finally begins to turn him east, toward somewhere the question might still be *alive*. **This is the midpoint of the book.**

#### **Movement 6 — The road to Agra, 1641–1651 (the counter-Inquisition) · Ch 14–18**

**Ch 14 (Isfahan / New Julfa, 1641 — the choice).** After Galileo’s trial Niccolò works the eastern roads for eight years but *deliberately* keeps off the one to Isfahan — going back would mean choosing, and he has spent his life never standing where he can be made to choose. A letter from the cold Cardinal Ottavio finally sends him over the passes: there is a Mughal prince, Dara Shikoh, who *gathers* forbidden books instead of burning them, and Rome wants to know what — and to skim some first. The only road to that prince runs through Marjan’s door. He finds Khoja Sarkis

three years dead, the house Marjan's now; they fall straight back into the old working partnership, the truest thing he has ever known. But on the eighth night she prices his errand to the bone: he loves only what is being carried out of the room, and this book-loving prince is exactly the kind the "careful brother" is already sharpening a knife for — Niccolò will buy well at his court, then bury him and ship the library home. She does *not* ask him to stay (to ask would only hand him something to be brave against). He goes anyway, knowing exactly what he is discarding — and on the road begins building, plank by plank, the lie of a return. This is where the cost of his life's choices starts coming due.

**Ch 15 (Surat, 1642–44 — the counting-house).** (*Frame: Tommaso, reading the old China letters, asks whether any throne ever paid a man for the truth instead of burning him.*) Niccolò reaches India by sea — and Surat is not the spice and elephants of the letters but a customs house in the standing rain. His consignment is held by a young English Company factor, Greaves, who invents fees, betting a lone old Frank can't gainsay him. The throne here is neither fire nor tribunal but a *ledger*. Niccolò beats him not by catching a fraud but by jurisdiction (the books cleared the Mughal's own customs), then leaves him a face-saving door — trading a season's Gulf market-intelligence for the release, because a counting-house has a long memory and a longer arm. At the Jesuit house the lonely padre Bernardo shows him the China correspondence: a German Jesuit, Schall, honoured by the Chinese emperor for fixing the calendar — given a court grade and **a button of coral**, the literal rank-insignia of the Chinese court, *for telling the Emperor the truth about the heavens* (the exact inverse of the penitent's shift Rome gave Galileo). These are the "**coral-button letters**" the book refers back to later. Niccolò *wants* this to be the throne that pays for truth — but spots the flaw he then chooses to ignore: the same packet carries news that the dynasty is collapsing — "the honour and the falling on two leaves of the one packet." He lets the button outshine the rebellion, because he wants the hope more than the caution. An honour is only worth the house that grants it. The newest and perhaps largest power he ever meets is the one that fears nothing, because to a counting-house a book is only freight.

**Ch 16 (Agra, ~1645 — the prince).** Up-country at last to Agra, the richest book-market on earth, worked from the lane behind the court. He reaches Dara Shikoh through the trade: first by quietly un-deceiving the prince's overworked secretary about a forged *Shahnama*, then by offering a great engraved European Bible he has carried for years "waiting for the right door." Dara — slender, pearled, soft uncalled hands, quick and generous — overpays three times the fair price for the sheer joy of it, and reads the scriptures side by side as one truth in many clothes. Niccolò loves him within the hour and has already buried him: a man who will not count the cost of a book will not count the cost of anything, and the open-handed candour that makes him beloved (said carelessly in front of a watchful orthodox judge) is the very habit that will kill him. The cell and the prince are the same room, gilded — the heretic housed better before the burning.

**Ch 17 (Delhi, ~1648–50 — choosing a side).** The court moves to the new capital, Shahjahanabad, and Niccolò has gone semi-permanent, the promised "season" long since unmonthed. He shows what the counter-Inquisition actually is — not a rumour but a payroll: Sufis, Brahmins, and Jesuits at one table, paid to copy out one another's scriptures. And he sees it is the *same machine* Rome ran, only backward — gathering truth instead of burning it, and just as deadly to the throne that



runs it. Then he crosses a line he never crossed in sixty years: rather than broker it from his cushion, he personally smuggles a forbidden Hindu scripture up from Benares into the project, using his Frank's not-mattering for once *for a side and not a price*. He knows it as he does it. He meets Sarmad — the naked, laughing mystic who says aloud what Dara only says carefully — who frightens him more than the prince did, because Sarmad has thrown away the discretion Niccolò survived sixty years on, and is still alive, *for now*. A smooth court-scholar, Mir Askari, is already near the prince, taking notes for the other side.

**Ch 18 (Surat, 1651 — the long net).** Sent back down to the coast on the prince's business, Niccolò returns to a changed Surat: Bernardo dead of fever, the Jesuit house in other hands. There he meets Michał Boym — a big-framed Polish Jesuit wasted yellow by illness — carrying a dying Ming court's letter the whole breadth of the earth to beg Rome for help, and already certain Rome will doubt the seal and give him nothing. The China hope of Ch 15 dies in front of him: a throne that paid for truth, fallen, its envoy a courier of hope already obsolete. Then, out of the dead padre's unsorted post, a letter surfaces — two sheets. A relation's flat note that Marjan died of a sickness in 1646; and Marjan's own undelivered letter, left with the house against the day the trade might place him. She has been dead five years. He has been building the road home to a grave — and the news came late not because the road was slow but because he gave it no name to follow; the very court he chose over her is what finally made him findable. He folds the two letters into his coat, clears the consignment, and goes back up the river to the prince, grief and service carried together, neither set down.

**Movement 7 — Delhi, and Rome, 1657–1665 (the second fire, and the entry) · Ch 19–25**

**Ch 19 (the new capital, 1657 — the book finished).** (*Frame: Tommaso keeps circling back to the uncatalogued Persian book he found at the dim end of the shelf.*) The *Sirr-i-Akbar* is finished the same autumn the old King falls ill. It is brought to Niccolò to be collated and bound — and because it is in Persian, his trade-tongue, it is the one book in his life whose secret he can read for himself, with no other man to tell him: the Hindus' oldest scriptures carried into Persian by Dara, with the prince's own signed preface arguing they are the *hidden book of God*, all faiths one water in many jars. What raises the hair on his arms is not the secret but the **title page** — a man does not hang for what he says of an evening, he hangs for what he signs. Meanwhile Mir Askari and a dry law-court official walk the shelves with a list, *making the evidence*. The court thins as the King's death-rumour spreads. Niccolò warns Dara sideways; the prince waves it off — “the truth could not hurt anyone.” Already the dealer in him is doing the sum, pricing the library of the man he loves — and there is no one left alive to whom he could even confess that he is doing it, Marjan eleven years in her grave at Julfa for want of the road he never gave her. He finishes the binding, sets the book back on the prince's shelf, and leaves it standing.

**Ch 20 (Agra, 1657–58 — the borrowed strength).** (*Frame: Tommaso counts the four sons on his fingers and looks unhappy at the number.*) Niccolò lays out the succession — four brothers, and a Mughal prince's strength is a *borrowed* thing, lent by the lords and soldiers and clergy and called in the instant the old King wavers. The King doesn't die, but the city behaves as if he had; Aurangzeb, the lean praying brother, lets Murad declare first so the sin of rising falls on the other man. The King is moved to the red fort at Agra, the library packed and barged down with the household.

Then the **charge** arrives — Aurangzeb’s cold, lawyerly dossier naming Dara an apostate, with the *Sirr* as the proof, every clause of it true. Dara is almost flattered and unpacks the book to admire his own preface. Niccolò sees the door home — a ship at Surat — and does not take it; he packs the library instead of himself, telling himself it is the trade, knowing it is the gladness — that the prince is the one open, glad lover of the question he has met in sixty years, and that the single soul who would have heard him say “I stayed for a man’s gladness” and not laughed has lain a dozen years at Julfa, for want of the road he never gave her. After the first defeat at Dharmat, Dara resolves to meet his brother in person at Samugarh, and carries the library to the battle.

**Ch 21 (Samugarh, May 1658 — the empty howdah).** The battle, fought in a furnace heat, watched from the baggage park half a mile behind the line by a near-blind old man who can only *read* it off the men around him. Dara rides out high in the **howdah** — the gilt canopied chair on the elephant — and calls down that he is glad the library has come; he will not leave his best regiment behind. For one cruel hour it goes well. Then the chair is empty: Dara has merely climbed down to a horse for the last push, but an army watches its prince, and a vacant howdah reads as *death* — the rumour breaks his line before the truth can get its boots on. The rout floods back through the carts. Niccolò lunges for the one case holding the *Sirr* and cannot shift it; he is knocked down between the wheels, and the library — his own life’s trade now worked upon *him* — scatters into the dust. He survives by being too old and small to be worth robbing. The secretary Mir Salih vanishes in the flood; Dara rides west into the dark with nothing.

**Ch 22 (Agra → Delhi, 1658–59 — no one’s man).** Niccolò gets back into an Agra that is changing masters, where he is known and marked as “the Frank of the heretic’s library.” He goes to the gutted book-house and finds Mir Askari installed at the writing-table like a new owner, and is asked — gently, the blade wrapped in courtesy — what he means to tell them back in Rome of all he has seen. He hears the real question (*are you going to be a problem?*) and answers it unprompted and whole: he is a tradesman for hire, a Frank and an unbeliever, the prince a closed account, the famous book no more to him than a ledger — and seals it with a joke. It works; he is waved off, free. The horror is that every word was true. He does not take the ship; he follows the boxes north to Delhi and spends the better part of a year *becoming no one*, while the news walks in behind him: Dara’s flight to Lahore and Sind, a second defeat below Ajmer, the death of his wife Nadira on the road (he sends his own dwindling guard away to bury her with honour), and the final betrayal by the Afghan chieftain Malik Jiwan, whose life Dara had twice spared. Aurangzeb is proclaimed Emperor.

**Ch 23 (Delhi, 1659 — among the weeping).** Dara is paraded into Delhi on a scabbed rubbish-hauler’s she-elephant — the humiliation done with deliberate care — and the whole city pours out and *weeps*, the exact opposite of the calm, fearless crowd at Bruno’s fire sixty years before. Niccolò watches through his lens from behind a pillar and keeps his face shut. He could have stepped into the light and let the doomed prince find, in all that strange country, one known face — and he does not, because to be seen grieving would write his own name onto the page beneath Dara’s, undoing the disavowal that bought his life. The naked mystic Sarmad finds him — not laughing, for once — and names him plainly: “the most honest man in this city, hiding in the dark,” who will never be safe because he has *kept too much*. A scribe is already writing Sarmad down. Niccolò

takes his sleeve back and walks away from the loud, doomed end of the question, leaving Sarmad to be entered into the book.

**Ch 24 (Delhi, 1659 — for almost nothing).** Niccolò is summoned to the fort to **label the captured library against its owner** at a trial whose verdict was settled years ago in a praying tent. He gives clean, accurate labels for a killing already decided — and this time, unlike Agra, his lie buys him nothing; he hands the truth away for free. Aurangzeb himself enters (drawn in full — lean, plain white, the dark prayer-callus worth more than all Dara's pearls), takes up the *Sirr*, and asks its worth. Niccolò prices it as goods; the Emperor sets his hand flat on the page and answers that he has appraised the box and not the thing in it — *this teaches that the line between true and false does not exist; I am the line* — the one man who ever measured the book exactly, his measure being the executioner's. Niccolò sees Dara cross the courtyard one last time, lens up so that he may see and not be seen — the worst use he ever made of his trade. Dara is beheaded the next night in the dark, the head sent down the river to Agra to the old fallen King. Then the poisoned library comes loose and cheap, and Niccolò — who stepped around such things his whole life — buys the hidden book off a frightened porter *for almost nothing*. He cuts the prince's ownership-seal from the flyleaf (a seal could hang its carrier) but, against the trade's reason, does not burn it: he wraps it in oiled cloth and keeps it, the one article he ever took from a falling house meaning never to sell it.

**Ch 25 (Rome, ~1665 — the uncatalogued book).** The telling is done. The old man finally does the one thing he climbed into the library every morning for four years to avoid: he writes the *Sirr-i-Akbar*'s catalogue entry — the book he has owned six years and never entered, because to write where it came from is to admit he was there and lifted no finger to prevent what happened. He writes it in full, and for the only time in sixty years sets down the *reason* for a price (the same act that made the book worth almost nothing made its maker worth killing), then corrects the shelf-count so book and shelf agree at last. In the writing he hears, sixty years late, what Bruno asked him in the cell — *what did they think they were burning, who told them they could reach so high* — and the cell's own answer: the truth was never the thing in danger; the men who say it are. Two things he keeps off every ledger he owns — the prince's seal in its oiled cloth, and **Marjan**: the Armenian book-keeper of New Julfa he loved, left without a forwarding word, and whose death reached him five years stale because he gave the news no road to follow. By his own first law — *a thing without an entry does not exist* — she does not exist, the law being true and the cruelest thing he knows. So he gives her the one entry that goes into no book at all: he says her name aloud to the boy. *Marjan*.